

As we get older, most of us notice a slight reduction in thinking speed as well as a reduction in our working memory (see p.135). Some people experience severe decline or even dementia (see p.200), but this is by no means inevitable. In fact, some cognitive capacities, such as our overall understanding of life, may even improve as we age.

We inherit our basic level of cognitive function from our parents, but this genetic blueprint is also affected by our environment and life experiences, including nutrition, health, education, stress levels, and relationships. Physically, socially, and intellectually stimulating activities also play a key role.

Preventing decline

We can take a variety of steps to safeguard our brain's health. A diet high in vegetables, fruit, "good" fats, and nutrients (see pp.54–55) keeps both brain and body healthy, as does moderate but regular physical activity. Jogging or other aerobic exercise can help delay age-related declines both in memory and thinking speed.

You can also protect your brain health by avoiding toxins, such as alcohol and tobacco. Smoking has been linked with damage to the brain's cortex. If you do drink alcohol, keep within healthy drinking limits and have at least two alcohol-free days per week.

Keep your mind stimulated. Any mental challenge that involves learning—from home repairs to cooking to crossword puzzles—can stretch cognitive skills. Consider learning a new language, as people who speak two or more languages have stronger cognitive ability than those who speak just one.

To sum up, you can slow the cognitive aging process by:

- **Keeping your brain well supplied with oxygen and nutrients.**
- **Avoiding exposure to toxins such as alcohol and nicotine.**
- **Exercising your body by building activity into daily life.**
- **Exercising your mind by learning new skills.**

How to Slow the Effects of Aging

As we age, our thinking and short-term memory may become less efficient. Nevertheless, we continue to learn until we die, and we can take active measures to keep our brain working well at any age.